Documentary Day 2: Interview Practice Worksheet

Name: _____ Persona: _____

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0) Guess the Story

I will show a short **silent image sequence** (no words, no sound).
Write a guess for what the core question and story could be.

What is the question the documentary is asking? What is this about?

> Images alone are powerful but **ambiguous.** Documentaries use **images + interviews/VO** to help audiences understand what's really going on.

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1) How This Works

Step 1 — Receive your persona.
Read it quietly. Imagine what this person is like. You may add small details to make it feel natural, but keep the three true facts private.

Step 2 — Prepare your interview strategy.
Develop 3 interview questions you would ask to find out your persona's three secret facts.

Step 3 — Interview your partner.
Use your prepared questions, actively listen, and ***follow-up naturally*** when something sounds interesting or surprising. Listen closely for clues, and find all three secret facts to win. You will have 5 minutes.

Step 4 — Switch Interviewer / Interviewee
Now switch. Get in character and answer honestly *as that persona* while your partner interviews you.

Step 5 — Reflect.
At the end, reveal your persona and compare how many secret facts each of you uncovered.

2) Interview Prep

Fill this out before interviewing.

Create 3 questions you would ask to find out your persona's 3 secret facts. All other questions you ask must be follow-up questions, or based on in-the-moment listening.

> *Journalism training encourages asking open-ended questions ("What do you think about that?", "Tell me more about that moment.") rather than yes/no or leading questions.*
>
> *Good interview technique says you should pause, give space for the person to think, and let silence lead to deeper reflection, and more answers.*

3 Prepared Questions:

1

2

3

Note Taking Space

3) Active Listening Checklist

☐ I paused a few seconds after big answers before replying.
☐ I asked a follow-up about something unexpected.
☐ I paraphrased once ("So you're saying ___?").
☐ I asked for a scene ("Can you take me to that moment?").
☐ I noticed tone or body language and asked about it.
☐ I avoided interrupting or rushing.
☐ I ended by asking what they wish people understood about them.

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4) Reflection

For the Interviewer:

1. What did you learn that you didn't expect?

2. What helped you uncover something real?

3. Which of the persona's three facts did you identify?

For the Persona:

1. Which of your facts did your partner discover?

2. What question or moment helped them find it?

Takeaway: A strong interviewer doesn't need to know the topic beforehand. They just have to listen closely enough to find the truth.